

Notions of **political liberation** spread across the territories colonized by the Spanish and Portuguese in **South America**.

These ideas **destabilize the Spanish administration** on the continent.

Bitter wars against colonial powers in South America lead to the creation of a newly independent Gran Colombia.

The new state faces **divisions and instabilities**. Hopes of unity are undermined by political infighting.

South America, racially and socially **dislocated**, consistently **struggles to assert itself** economically and politically.



Simón Bolívar

Born in Caracas, Venezuela, in 1783, Simón Bolívar came from one of the oldest and wealthiest noble families in the city. His education was completed in Europe, where he absorbed the republican ideals of the American and French revolutions. The idea of independence for Hispanic America accordingly took root in his imagination.

His revolutionary career began with an abortive uprising in Caracas in 1810. In 1814, the charismatic Bolívar declared himself “liberator” and head of state of the new republic of Venezuela. In 1817, he staged a daring invasion of Colombia and went on to complete the conquests of Ecuador and Peru in 1824. Bolívar’s dream was to unite all of South America—except Argentina, Brazil, and Chile—in a single great republic. However, his dictatorial tendencies and the brutality of his armies eventually led to dissent and the fracturing of Gran Colombia in 1830, the year of his death.

There are clear parallels with the American Revolution. But while in North America it was the fundamental liberties of free-born men that were disputed, in Brazil the issue was narrower—it was simply a question of who would govern.

In 1822, to protect the interests of the native-born elite, Pedro declared Brazil an independent constitutional monarchy and himself its emperor. This was a revolution only in the sense that it produced Brazilian independence in the interests of those already ruling it. One of the more obvious consequences was that, with no change to the social or economic order, slavery remained legal in Brazil until 1888, later than anywhere else in the Western world.

Governing Spain's colonies

In Spain’s colonies, the drive for independence stemmed partly from the desire of the native-born »